For 17-year-old Rohan Malhotra (name changed), a student in a prominent Delhi school, skincare is a performance. Mornings begin with a charcoal cleanser, a swipe of exfoliating toner and a sunscreen he reapplies with almost ceremonial discipline. Between classes, he checks his reflection, smooths a dab of gel through his carefully styled curls and mists a citrus face spray. Evenings end with sheet masks, under-eye patches and a meticulous hair routine inspired by Korean pop stars. "Looking good is confidence," he laughs, arranging serums on his desk like trophies. For Rohan and many urban teens like him, beauty is not vanity, it's self-expression, social currency and a little daily theatre in the mirror.

Walk into a modern men's salon in Mumbai or Gurugram and you'll see how far Indian grooming has travelled from the simple haircut-and-shave routine. Waxing strips designed specifically for men's coarse body hair, de-tanning facials branded as 'CEO glow therapies', collagen-boosting under-eye masks to combat late-night screen fatigue, and even pedicure stations offering 'sports foot scrubs' are now standard menu items. Premium spas are pushing beard spa treatments with hot oils and serums, while the men's section of online platforms like Nykaa are stocking BB (beauty balm, for the uninitiated) creams, anti-acne serums, tinted moisturisers, concealers, brow gels.

More men are booking facials, body polishing sessions, deep-cleansing pedicures and hair spa treatments; wearing compression vests that smooth the torso; and stacking rings, chains and earrings. Even fragrance has undergone a change: floral, sweet and unisex perfumes once marketed almost exclusively to women now make up some of the most-reviewed men's scents online. "Men are getting comfortable trying facials, sheet masks or basic makeup," says Sachin Parmar, one of the country's most visible male skincare influencers. "Earlier, men thought skincare was only for women. Now, they realise taking care of your skin is not gendered. Men want to feel confident. They want to look clean and put-together, not rugged by default."

$4.3 BILLION

The projected size of the male grooming industry in India by 2033, a nearly twofold increase from 2024

Source: IMARC



A HANDSOME BOOM

Taking note of this clear shift in male behaviour towards self-care, the beauty and wellness market, too, has pivoted. According to the IMARC consulting group, the male grooming market in India touched $2.3 billion (Rs 21,169 crore) in 2024 and is expected to nearly double to $4.3 billion (Rs 39,577 crore) by 2033. A host of Indian companies catering exclusively to male grooming products has sprung up over the past decade, like The Man Company, Beardo and Bombay Shaving Company. With men starting to form a meaningful share of its customer base, online retailer Nykaa launched Nykaa Man in 2018, offering products as well as expert tips on grooming, hygiene and personal care. Suddenly, grooming products for men aren't a novelty category—they're a core business driver in the Indian beauty economy.

The biggest challenge companies selling cosmetics to men faced was from the customers themselves. When Hitesh Dhingra founded The Man Company, his chief mission was moving Indian men beyond the basic deodorant-and-shaving cream purchase. Shantanu Deshpande, founder and CEO of Bombay Shaving Company, used targeted digital ads to build an education campaign in a product category where customers "just don't talk" about what they buy. Beardo, founded by Ashutosh Valani and Priyank Shah, had to convince Indian men that products like beard oil and beard wash were legitimate grooming essentials and not vanity items; they competed against inexpensive unbranded oils and worked to

" GEN-Z AND MILLENNIALS SEE JEWELLERY AS SELF-EXPRESSION, NOT STATUS. MEN TODAY WANT PIECES THAT FIT THEIR PERSONALITY INSTEAD OF THEIR GENDER "

ISHENDRA AGARWAL
Founder, Giva



Photograph by **HARDIK CHHABRA;** *Location courtesy:* NSH, DEFENCE COLONY